

LOCOMOTIF IS. PRASANNARAJAN

Dubya Revised

History, we don't know. We'll all be dead." Thus spoke George W. Bush when asked about the judgment of history on his war in Iraq. A piece of Bushism or accidental wisdom from a man who was every liberal caricaturist's favorite moron. One thing we, the living, do know: it was more than he could handle, the bloody burst of history that accompanied his presidency. It began one flaming morning in September 2001, when he was transported from the idyllic pages of *My Pet Goat* to the swirling centre of the post-Berlin Wall world. It was a journey semaphored by history, and the traveller, the very legitimacy of whose election was in question then, looked awfully ill-equipped for the mission. The reality magnified by the glow of 9/11 marked the next big shift after the fall of communism. The New Evil Imperium was not a geographical entity; it was the mind of the killer, accessorized by the Book and the gun. Bush, the born-again Christian, too, resorted to the morality of the Book as he faced up to the enemy. Suddenly, the presidency became an office of liberation. Afghanistan was the first blast of the just war, and the de-Talibanisation of Afghanistan was followed by the disintegration of al Qaeda. Post-Tora Bora, Osama bin Laden and Ayman al-Zawahiri were either disembodied voices or grainy images on a video tape. And Bush, whose presidency was fast turning Biblical, took the war to the heart of Evil. Iraq, just war part two, was the transformative moment: the fall of Saddam Hussain was the triumph; the liberator cracking up was the tragedy.

On the eve of Barack Obama's inauguration as the 44th president of America, Bush, his popularity rating at its lowest, looks much smaller than his presidential size. In the liberal narrative, he is a historical anomaly. Is he? Is Bush the worst America has experienced in the twenty first century? He is if you still miss Saddam and if you still believe that radical Islam's rage against civilisation is an inevitable rejoin-

der to colonial injustices. Reducing the entire Bush legacy to the mess in Mesopotamia is to deny the man his role in bringing the urgency of war for national survival to the global consciousness. America's war in Iraq may have become universally unpopular, and the only good thing that has come out of it may be the Obama revolution. His war, no matter how the Americans rate it, has become everybody's war. It is our war too, though we, being Indians, won't take it to the enemy quarters. As argued by Jacob Weisberg in *The Bush Tragedy*, W's war may have a Shakespearean dimension: Dubya as King Henry V, whose invasion of France is a son's astounding heroism after the father's cautious, passive reign. His moral activism in an age of stoic nationalism has made us aware of the madness of faith, our common threat after the fantasy of ideology.



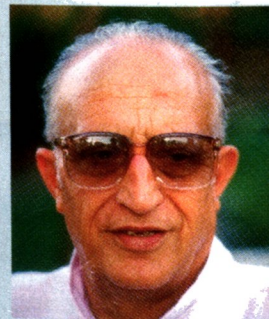
DIED: Former Davis Cup player **Premjit Lall**, 68. He was a recipient of the Arjuna Award and a four-time national tennis cham-



pion. He had been confined to a wheelchair following a crippling accident in 1992.

DIED: Pandit **Ramashreya Jha**, 81, composer, musician and scholar of Indian classical music. He was the Head of the Department of Music at Allahabad University from 1980 to 1989.

DIED: **G.M. Shah**, former chief minister of Jammu & Kashmir



and president of the Awami National Conference. He was chief minister from 1984 to 1986.

WON: By **Mahesh Mangaonkar**, the boys under-15 title at the British Junior Open squash tournament at Sheffield, England.



SAURABH SINGH